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Project 2: Literature Review - Reflection
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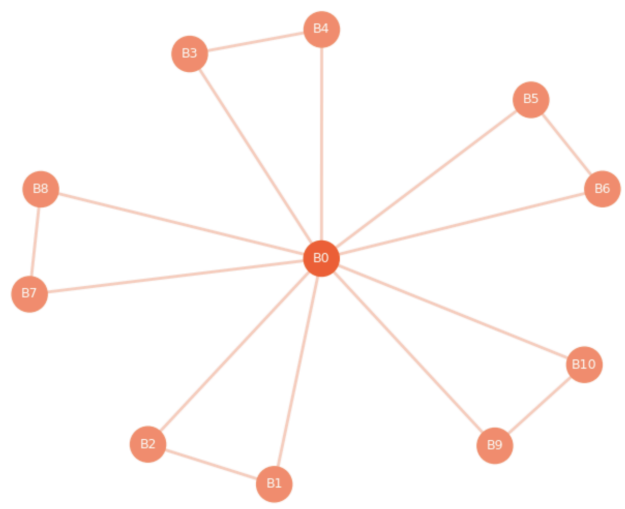
The literature review assignment stood out to me because it demanded a different way of thinking. I know I mentioned this in my project 1 reflection, but every assignment in this class has taught me a different way of organizing all my ideas and bringing them to life. Instead of building on a single topic with ten supportive sources, we mapped what each source revealed and connected them like a static network. This is a type of visualization I learned about in my Data Science 4200 class towards the end of this project and it helped me connect everything. I find that taking at least one data science class a semester has helped me better understand the content taught in class, and one of them would be writing.



The picture above shows the first static network visualization I saw in class. The static network visualization showed me how everything is connected and overlaps, which is exactly what occurred in my paper. When I created the framework organizing cultural factors from language (most immediate) to discrimination (broadest societal), I was essentially mapping a network of relationships. Language connects to health literacy, which connects to acculturation, which connects to famillismo, which all interact with discrimination. These aren't isolated factors, they're nodes in an interconnected system.

Why synthesis matters: I think CEOs and hiring managers value people who can read across reports because synthesis reveals patterns individual sources can't show. When I compared Loya et al.'s and Zlatar et al.'s physical activity interventions in Table 7, they both had high retention rates (90.5% and 100%) through different delivery models. This revealed that cultural adaptation itself, not the specific format, drives engagement, a finding neither study alone could demonstrate if not compared.

Unexpected discoveries: An unexpected discovery I noticed in my paper is how familismo operates dually, not uniformly. I expected family orientation to be purely protective and have a positive light, but synthesizing three studies revealed complexity. In smoking cessation, family support helped some participants while family demands triggered smoking in others. In dementia care, caregivers experienced isolation when families didn't share responsibilities, contradicting cultural expectations. This double nature emerged only by examining multiple studies as a network of evidence, not individual data points.

When creating Figure 2 in Jupyter Notebook helped make invisible patterns visible. Mexican/Mexican American populations appeared in 9 of 10 studies while Cuban and Dominican groups appeared in only one each. Visualizing this disparity revealed a fundamental limitation, we can't claim to understand "Hispanic health behaviors" when we've barely studied most Hispanic subgroups.

Process changes: For this second project I took the layer approach. This was done by organizing all ten studies (Table 1) which then became my foundation.. The multilevel framework helped me notice patterns in how factors operated at different levels: language affects daily interactions, familismo shapes family dynamics, health literacy mediates individual knowledge, discrimination operates societally. My research process grew from overwhelming to intentional. Initially, broad searches for "Hispanic health behaviors" yielded thousands of results. I changed my strategy to combine specific cultural factors (familismo, acculturation, health literacy) with health domains and the 2025 date restriction. This targeted approach found the right sources, not just more sources.

What I'd change: Given more time, I would expand databases beyond Embase, PsycINFO, and ProQuest. I would search more deliberately for studies on underrepresented Hispanic subgroups, the Mexican/Mexican American overrepresentation limits my

review's applicability to Cuban, Dominican, Central American, and South American communities. I would examine intersectionality more deeply, how cultural factors interact with gender, socioeconomic status, sexual orientation, and disability.

Transferable skills: This assignment helped me advance how I detect patterns across sources, which is important when recognizing that different study designs answer different questions with different levels of certainty, creating figures and tables that convey complexity efficiently, and acknowledging what we don't know. The absence of randomized controlled trials meant none of these studies establish causation, recognizing this gap isn't a weakness it's guiding future research priorities.

Why students remember this project: I believe students remember this assignment because it's one of the few pieces of writing that really gets us thinking and learning about the variety of ways one can approach a complex research question. Throughout this project, I deeply valued the in-class activities that taught us practical research skills I'd never participated in my three years at Northeastern. Writing out our sources to visualize connections between authors helped me see patterns I wouldn't have noticed otherwise. Learning about predatory journals was eye-opening, I've been here since Fall 2025, taking research-based related courses, and never knew to check journal quality beyond "is it peer-reviewed?". Students remember this assignment because it requires thinking differently, writing differently, and producing something genuinely useful, a map of what we know, what we don't know, and where to go next.

Most useful feedback: The most valuable guidance came during my one-on-one meeting with you Dr. Musselman, when you suggested condensing the detailed information about data and authors into tables rather than keeping everything in writing. This recommendation helped enhance my paper. Creating the tables, especially Table 7 comparing the two physical activity interventions, not only reduced word count significantly but made patterns immediately visible. My friend Sierra confirmed this when she reviewed my draft, noting how much easier the tables made it to compare findings across studies.